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Ex-UBS bankers' boutique aims to double assets to $2bn in a year

Founded by Mary Chiu and Yugi Lee, Hong Kong-based Blackhorn Wealth Management currently has $1bn in assets under management and employs around 15 staff, including six client advisors.

by JILL WONG
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Helping to invest clients' money is one of the core duties of private bankers, but some go even further by investing their own money in the wealth management business.

Former UBS bankers Mary Chiu (pictured left) and Yugi Lee (pictured right) set up Hong Kong-based independent asset manager, Blackhorn Wealth Management, in 2021 to provide wealth management services to ultra-high-net-worth clients. They also set up Blackhorn Family Office to provide services such as estate planning and tax advisory, to well-heeled families.

The duo say they decided to join hands and invest in a wealth management business because of their complimentary skill sets and personalities. Chiu focuses on investments and the operational side of the business, with Lee heading relationship management. Both saw potential from extending their friendship into a business partnership despite the economic downturn caused by the Covid-19 pandemic.

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So how did the former bankers make the shift to being entrepreneurs?

'We have to look at the profit and loss and that's always stressful, but we believe that we cannot always wait for the perfect timing or opportunity. There will be a lot of growth during the next decade. We gave ourselves a year or two to grow the platform and we do feel that we are on track,' Chiu told Citywire Asia.

'It's a lot more work and responsibility to run our own business as compared to being corporate employees. We manage the team and we're learning to wear more hats than we did previously.'

Chiu started her career with Morgan Stanley after completing her master's degree in 2010. In 2013, she joined UBS as director of global family office's Greater China division, managing $4bn of client assets across Asia. After working there for close to two years, she joined her own family office to manage investments and remained there for over five years before setting up Blackhorn.

Lee started her career at Credit Suisse in 2014 and joined UBS a year later as a director in wealth management, where she managed portfolios for ultra-high-net-worth families and listed companies. She spent six years at UBS before leaving last year to set up Blackhorn.

'We get along very well and really enjoy working with each other. That's a very important thing in terms of forming a business and partnership,' Lee said

Blackhorn Wealth Management currently has $1bn of assets under management and around 15 staff, including six client advisors. The firm hopes to increase its headcount of client advisors to 10 by the end of this year. It is also targeting doubling its assets under management and pool of relationship managers by the end of next year.

The firm's recruitment drive is focused on hiring experienced bankers from top-tier private banks. 'When we speak to advisors, we need to know that they are trusted and have strong relationships with their clients, and that they can work independently. In the larger banks, you have a lot more support internally. Our client advisors need to have their own views and the ability to execute on the portfolios,' Chiu added.

Blackhorn's investment decisions are the responsibility of its advisory board and actioned on by their investment management consulting team, which comprises former UBS private bankers Wong Po Sum, Danika Ma and Gregory Ng.

Wong has over 30 years of experience in wealth management and was at UBS for 13 of those before joining Blackhorn. Ma worked at the Swiss bank between 2018 and 2021. Ng joined Blackhorn from Morgan Stanley, but had a five-year prior spell at UBS servicing high-net-worth clients.

Additionally, Jody Leung joined Blackhorn as an advisor to the board. Leung was previously managing director and chief investment officer of Nan Fung Trinity Capital, the investment arm of property developer Nan Fung Group. There she was responsible for managing the investment portfolios of the group, as well as those of its founding family members.

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